



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

JOY AND REMEMBRANCE

Altadena’s annual Christmas tree lighting ceremony on Santa Rosa Avenue — a.k.a. Christmas Tree Lane this time of year — felt like a festive memorial in the fire-devastated community. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

State urged to protect children online

Legislators must do more to restrict social media and AI, parents and advocates say.

By KATIE KING

SACRAMENTO — Julianna Arnold wasn’t alarmed when her teen daughter first joined Instagram. Many people her age were using it. And her daughter Coco had a social life and other hobbies, like track and gymnastics, to

balance out her time online. “It was music and dancing videos and it seemed innocent,” said Arnold, who resides in Los Angeles, explaining that she would look over the content Coco watched. But Arnold said a man used Instagram to target her daughter while they were living in New York in 2022, sending private messages and acting like a “big brother” to earn her trust. Two weeks after her 17th birthday, Coco met him near her home — and died after taking a fentanyl-laced fake Percocet that he provided.

Similar stories are playing out nationwide as parents grapple with how to protect their children from myriad threats online. As the state is home to many tech giants, Gov. Gavin Newsom has said California is paving the way for legislative restrictions on social media and artificial intelligence. But while child safety advocates agree progress was made at the state capital this year, they contend that there’s still a long way to go and plan to fight for more protections when legislators reconvene in January. “I would say California is

definitely leading on this,” said Jai Jaisimha, co-founder of the Transparency Coalition, a nonprofit researching the risks and opportunities associated with AI. But “I would love to see a willingness to be a bit stronger in terms of understanding the impacts and taking action faster. We can’t afford to wait three or four years — harm is happening now.” A survey last year from the Pew Research Center found nearly half of U.S. teens ages 13 to 17 say they’re online “almost constantly.” Nine in 10 teens said they use [See Children, A7]

Schiff takes aim at Trump and affordability

In first year in Senate, he remains a White House foil and carries his party’s message.

By KEVIN RECTOR

Five months after joining the U.S. Senate, Adam Schiff delivered a floor speech on what he called “the top 10 deals for Donald Trump and the worst deals for the American people.” Schiff spoke of Trump and his family getting rich off cryptocurrency and cutting new development deals across the Middle East, and of the president accepting a free jet from the Qatari government. Meanwhile, he said, ordinary Americans were losing their healthcare, getting priced out of the housing market and having to “choose between rent or groceries.” “Trump gets rich. You get screwed,” the Democrat said. The speech was classic Schiff — an attempt by the former prosecutor to wrangle a complex set of graft allegations against Trump and his orbit into a single, cohesive corruption case

against the president, all while serving up his own party’s preferred messaging on rising costs and the lack of affordability. It was also a prime example of the tack Schiff has taken since being sworn in one year ago to finish the final term of the late Sen. Dianne Feinstein, a titan of California politics who held the seat for more than 30 years before dying in office in 2023. Schiff — now serving his own six-year term — has remained the unblinking antagonist to Trump that many Californians elected him to be after watching him dog the president from the U.S. House during Trump’s first term in the White House. He’s also continued to serve as one of the Democratic Party’s most talented if cerebral messengers, hammering Trump over his alleged abuses of power and the lagging economy, which has become one of the president’s biggest liabilities. Schiff has done so while also defending himself against Trump’s accusations that he committed mortgage fraud on years-old loan documents; responding to the devastating [See Schiff, A7]

Crackdown turns to legal immigration

Since D.C. attack, official pathways toward citizenship also hit a roadblock.

By SUHAUNA HUSSAIN, ANDREA CASTILLO AND RACHEL URANGA

WASHINGTON — Sophia Nyazi’s husband, Milad, shook her awake at 8 a.m. “ICE is here,” he told her. Three uniformed Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents were downstairs at the family’s home on Long Island, N.Y., on Tuesday, according to a video reviewed by The Times that she captured from atop the staircase. Nyazi said the agents asked whether her husband was applying for a green card. They told her they would have to detain him because of the shooting of two National Guard members a week earlier in Washington. “He has nothing to do with that shooting,” Nyazi, 27, recalled answering. “We don’t even know that person.” Her protests didn’t matter. The Trump administration has put into motion a broad and unprecedented

set of policy changes aimed at substantially limiting legal immigration avenues, including for immigrants long considered the most vulnerable. Milad Nyazi, 28, was detained because, like the man charged in the shooting which left one National Guard member dead, he is from Afghanistan. The administration has paused decisions on all applications filed with U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services, or USCIS, by people seeking asylum. The visa and immigration applications of Afghans, whom the U.S. had welcomed in 2021 as it pulled all troops from the country, have been halted. Officials also froze the processing of immigration cases of people from 19 countries the administration considers “high-risk” and will conduct case-by-case reviews of green cards and other immigration benefits given to people from those countries since then-President Biden took office in 2021. Immigration lawyers say they learned that dozens of naturalization ceremonies and interviews for green cards are being canceled for [See Immigration, A4]

L.A. preschools struggle to compete

As transitional kindergarten expands and thrives, the state sees unintended fallout

By Jenny Gold



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

ANGELINA PRESCHOOL in Los Angeles has seen its enrollment decline as parents move toward transitional kindergarten.

During the first four years of California’s new transitional kindergarten program, 167 community-based preschools in Los Angeles County shut down, unable to financially survive amid enrollment drops or pivot to more costly infant and toddler care, according to new UC Berkeley research. The closures represent some painful and unintended consequences of the state’s ambitious rollout of transitional kindergarten, or TK — a signature education program of Gov. Gavin Newsom that provides universal public preschool to every 4-year-old, researchers found. The loss of community preschools has meant that some families of children younger than 4 have had to scramble to find other day care in an already delicate network. At least in some cases, rather than bolstering California’s child-care sector and serving more children, TK instead appears to be competing with — and even replacing — local preschools, as they struggle to take in younger children, according to the study. Areas that experienced the largest growth in TK enrollment were also the most likely to suffer preschool closures. [See Preschool, A8]

OpenAI loses force as stock market savior

By RYAN VLASTELICA

Wall Street’s sentiment toward companies associated with artificial intelligence is shifting, and it’s all about two companies: OpenAI is down, and Alphabet Inc. is up. The maker of ChatGPT is no longer seen as being on the cutting edge of AI technology and is facing questions about its lack of profitability and the need to grow rapidly to pay for its massive spending commitments. Meanwhile, Google’s parent is emerging as a deep-pocketed competitor with tentacles in every part of the AI trade. “OpenAI was the golden child earlier this year, and Alphabet was looked at in a very different light,” said Brett Ewing, chief market

strategist at First Franklin Financial Services. “Now sentiment is much more tempered toward OpenAI.” As a result, the shares of companies in OpenAI’s orbit — principally Oracle Corp., CoreWeave Inc. and Advanced Micro Devices Inc. but also Microsoft Corp., Nvidia Corp. and SoftBank, which has an 11% stake in the company — are coming under heavy selling pressure. Meanwhile, Alphabet’s momentum is boosting not only its stock price but also those it’s associated with, such as Broadcom Inc., Lumentum Holdings Inc., Celectica Inc. and TTM Technologies Inc. The shift has been dramatic in magnitude and speed. Just a few weeks ago, OpenAI was sparking huge rallies in any company related [See OpenAI, A12]

La Niña? El Niño? Wet winter perplexes

By RONG-GONG LIN II

Californians can be excused for being confused about the weather forecast. Scientists in October said La Niña had arrived, which many associate with dry conditions, particularly in the Southland. But we have instead experienced a very wet season — at least so far — with rain bringing much-needed moisture to the brush, probably putting an end to the autumn fire season, and helping to keep the state’s reservoirs in good shape.



GINA FERRAZZI Los Angeles Times

RECENT STORMS didn’t bring much powder for ski resorts. Above, Snow Summit in Big Bear Lake.

So what is going on? It is still true that La Niña tends to correlate with dry water years, which the National Weather Service defines as from Oct. 1 to Sept. 30. During La Niña, the sea surface temperatures of the central and eastern Pacific Ocean cool. And the jet stream — the west-to-east band of wind in the atmosphere — shifts northward. This typically pushes winter storms toward the Pacific Northwest and Canada, while leaving swaths of California drier than average, es- [See La Niña, A9]

Mali atrocities linked to Russia

Witnesses describe rapes and beheadings by Moscow’s successor to Wagner Group mercenaries. **WORLD, A2**

Just what is ‘AI slop’ after all?

The masses are united in their disdain, but the term is ill-defined, Michael Hiltzik writes. **BUSINESS, A12**

Rams return to form with rout

They rebound from a sloppy loss with a 45-17 thrashing of Arizona to reclaim the NFC’s top spot. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather

Mostly sunny, warm. L.A. Basin: 78/57. **B6**

